ZONE startUP

FOR OVERSEAS INVESTORS

Your UAE licence in 1 day*

The fast, simple guide to starting your company in a UAE free zone, from your first call to your residence visa, without leaving home for the licence.

1 day	~2 weeks	100%	1,000+
licence issued*	to your residence visa	foreign ownership	companies set up

*SHAMS and ANCFZ, for standard activities with complete documents. Terms on page 03. November 2026 edition.

YOUR JOURNEY

Three stages to open for business

Your licence is the fast part. The visa and bank account follow, and we run them side by side so you're trading as quickly as possible.

STAGE 1

Trade licence

1 working day*

Choose your free zone, send your documents, complete KYC and e-sign. Your licence is issued the same day.

STAGE 2

Residence visa

About 2–3 weeks

Establishment card, entry permit, medical test and Emirates ID. You visit the UAE for about a week.

STAGE 3

Bank & tax

Runs alongside

Open your corporate bank account and register for Corporate Tax within 90 days.



0%
personal income tax

9%
Corporate Tax, 0% on the first AED 375,000

100%
ownership, no local partner

Online
licence setup from anywhere

THE 1-DAY PROMISE

What makes 1 day possible

Free zones like SHAMS and ANCFZ run fully digital licensing. With three things in place, your licence can be issued on the same working day we submit it.

1

Documents ready

Clear passport scans, photo, 3 company name options and contact details, all received before we submit.

2

Shareholders on hand

Every shareholder completes the online KYC tasks and e-signs the MOA on the same day.

3

A standard activity

Most trading, consulting, media and e-commerce activities qualify. We confirm yours in your first call.

* Terms & conditions

1. Licence in 1 working day is available for SHAMS and ANCFZ (also SPC and AFZ). IFZA and RAKEZ licences typically take about a week.
2. All documents must be complete, clear and received before submission. Unclear scans or missing items restart the clock.
3. Activities that need an outside approval (for example from a ministry, regulator or municipality) take longer. Some approvals are needed before the licence, others after it.
4. The free zone may request enhanced due diligence (EDD), for example for certain nationalities, activities, sources of funds or business models. EDD adds time and the free zone's decision is final.
5. Security checks, where required, must be cleared first. Corporate shareholders need attested company documents, which adds time.
6. Working days only (Monday to Friday, excluding UAE public holidays) and subject to free zone systems being available.
7. Licence and visa approvals are at the sole discretion of the free zone and UAE authorities.

STAGE 1 · LICENCE

Your licence day, step by step

Six steps, one working day, all online. Here's who does what.

1	**Pick your activity & free zone** A quick call or WhatsApp chat. We match your business to the right activity and free zone.	YOU + STARTUP ZONE
2	**Send your documents** Passport scans, photo, 3 name options and contact details for every shareholder.	YOU
3	**We submit & you pay** We prepare and submit your application. You pay the package fee.	STARTUP ZONE
4	**Complete your KYC** A short online compliance task on the free zone portal for each shareholder.	YOU & SHAREHOLDERS
5	**E-sign your MOA** Sign your Memorandum of Association online. No travel needed.	ALL SHAREHOLDERS
6	**Licence issued** Your trade licence, MOA, share certificate and lease agreement arrive by email.	FREE ZONE

You're officially a UAE company owner.
Next: your establishment card and visa.

Day 1 ✓

CHOOSE YOUR FREE ZONE

Four free zones, one partner

All four offer 100% foreign ownership and remote setup.

SHAMS

1-day licence*

Sharjah Media City · Sharjah

Licence from
AED 6,885 / year

With 1 visa, year 1 from AED 14,295 (health insurance by you)

Best for: Media, creative, consulting and e-commerce

- Up to 5 activities, up to 10 shareholders
- Virtual office lease and share certificate included
- Bank account opening support (Wio / Mashreq Neo)

ANCFZ

1-day licence*

Ajman Nuventure Centre Free Zone · Ajman

Licence from
AED 4,888 / year

With 1 visa, all-in year 1 from AED 10,800

Best for: Startups, freelancers and budget-conscious founders

- Up to 10 activities, up to 10 shareholders
- All-inclusive packages from 0 to 7 visas
- Visa, medical, Emirates ID and change of status included

IFZA

About 1 week

International Free Zone Authority · Dubai

Licence from
AED 12,900 / year

With 1 visa, all-in year 1 from AED 22,050

Best for: Consultancy, trading and tech wanting a Dubai address

- 3 activities and 3 shareholders included
- 15% off the licence on 2-year packages
- Dubai address and strong recognition

RAKEZ

About 1 week

Ras Al Khaimah Economic Zone · Ras Al Khaimah

Licence from
AED 6,000 / year

1-visa bundles from AED 12,000 (RAKEZ package price)

Best for: Trading, manufacturing and growing teams

- All-in bundles: licence, lease and establishment card
- Each visa includes entry permit, medical and Emirates ID
- Same bundle price every year at renewal

Prices as of November 2026, subject to change. SHAMS, ANCFZ and IFZA include our service fee; RAKEZ shows the RAKEZ package price, service fee quoted separately. Mainland or another free zone? Ask us.

GET READY

Your document checklist

Have these ready before your licence day. Clear scans are the single biggest time saver.

For your licence

- [ ] Clear colour scan of every shareholder's passport (photos of passports not accepted)
- [ ] Passport-size photo of each shareholder (white background)
- [ ] At least 3 options for your company name
- [ ] Phone, email and home address of each shareholder
- [ ] UAE visa or Emirates ID copy, if a shareholder lives in the UAE

For each visa

- [ ] Passport copy of each applicant (at least 6 months valid)
- [ ] Passport-size photo (white background)
- [ ] Visit visa or entry stamp copy, if the applicant is already in the UAE
- [ ] Health insurance for each visa holder

If a company is the shareholder

- [ ] Certificate of incorporation or trade licence of the parent company
- [ ] Memorandum & Articles of Association of the parent company
- [ ] Board resolution appointing the company's representative
- [ ] Documents issued outside the UAE must be legalised / attested

STAGE 2 · VISA

Your residence visa in about 2 weeks



1 Establishment card

Lets your company sponsor visas. Applied right after your licence.

2–3 days

2 E-visa (entry permit)

Your permit to enter the UAE as a future resident.

1–2 days

3 Change of status

Only if you're already in the UAE on a visit visa.

2 days

4 Medical test

Quick blood test and X-ray at an approved centre.

2 days

5 Emirates ID biometrics

Fingerprints and photo for your Emirates ID.

4 days

6 Residency issued

Your residence visa, linked to your Emirates ID.

3 days

PLAN YOUR TRIP

You must be in the UAE for the medical test and Emirates ID biometrics. Plan about a week here. We book your appointments around your flights.

GOOD TO KNOW

Health insurance is mandatory for every visa holder. If you have never entered the UAE before, a visit visa may be needed first. Visa approval is at the discretion of UAE immigration.

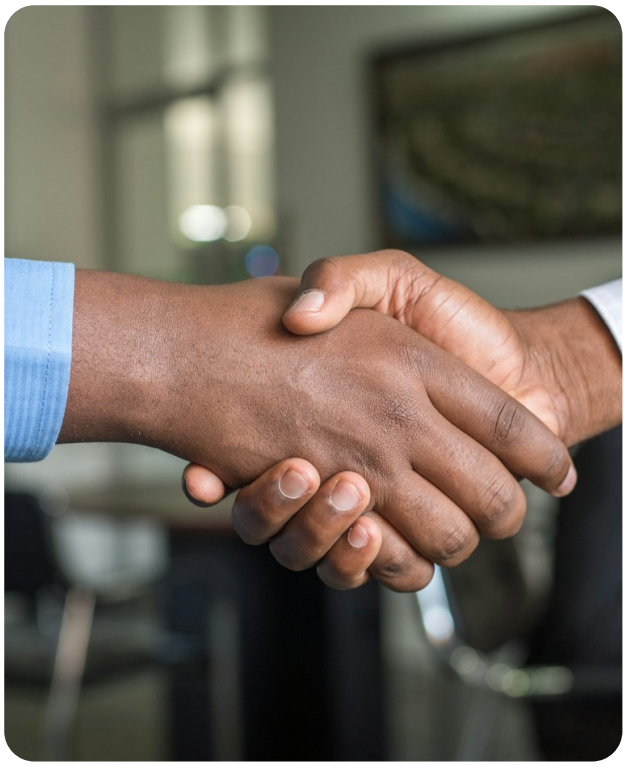
STAGE 3 · BANK

Open your corporate bank account

Banks approve businesses they understand. A complete, clear file is your fastest route to a yes. Digital banks can open in days; traditional banks often take a few weeks.

Bank readiness checklist

- [ ] Trade licence, MOA and share certificate
- [ ] Passport, residence visa and Emirates ID of each signatory
- [ ] A short business plan with expected monthly turnover
- [ ] CV or LinkedIn profile showing your experience
- [ ] Proof of source of funds and 6 months of personal bank statements
- [ ] Contracts, invoices or letters of intent from clients



PRO TIP

Write one page on who your customers are, and where money comes from and goes to. It answers the bank's main questions before they ask.

WE HELP

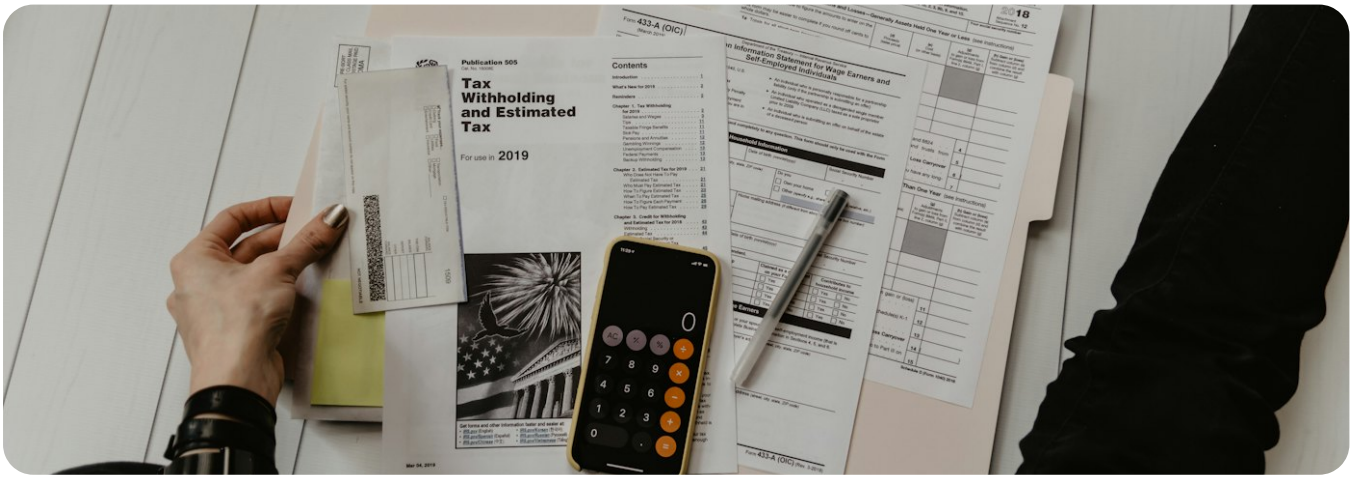
We introduce you to banks that suit your nationality, activity and trading countries, including fast digital options like Wio and Mashreq Neo.

STAGE 3 · TAX & COMPLIANCE

Stay compliant from day one

The key dates every UAE company owner should know. Put them in your calendar now.

What	When	Key point
Corporate Tax registration	Within 90 days of incorporation	Late registration penalty: AED 10,000
Corporate Tax return	Every year	Due within 9 months of financial year end
VAT registration	When turnover qualifies	Voluntary from AED 187,500; mandatory from AED 375,000
VAT return	Every quarter	Due within 28 days of quarter end
Licence renewal	Every year	Renew before expiry to avoid fines
Visa & Emirates ID	Typically every 2 years	Avoid staying outside the UAE more than 6 months in a row
Changes to the company	When they happen	Shareholder changes and amendments must also be updated with the FTA



Let us handle it: Startup Zone's accounting team takes care of bookkeeping, VAT and Corporate Tax registrations and returns, and reminds you of every renewal.

FAQ

Questions investors ask us

Q. Is the licence really issued in one day?

Yes, for SHAMS and ANCFZ when your documents are complete, your activity needs no outside approval and no extra checks are requested. See the terms on page 03.

Q. Do I need to travel to the UAE?

Not for your licence: it's fully online. You visit for about a week for your visa medical test and Emirates ID.

Q. Can I own 100% of my company?

Yes. All four free zones in this guide allow 100% foreign ownership.

Q. What if my activity needs an approval?

We tell you in your first call, explain the extra time and cost, and handle the approval for you.

Q. Will I pay tax?

No personal income tax. Your company pays 9% Corporate Tax on profit above AED 375,000, or 0% on qualifying free zone income. VAT is 5% once registered.

Q. Can you handle my accounting too?

Yes. Bookkeeping, VAT and Corporate Tax registrations and returns, all under one roof.

Important: This guide is general information correct as of November 2026. It is not legal or tax advice. Fees, processing times and requirements are set by the free zones and UAE authorities, change regularly and vary by activity, nationality and bank. Licence and visa approvals are at the authorities' sole discretion. Photos: Unsplash.



Start your licence today.

Send us your passport and business idea on WhatsApp. We'll confirm your activity, free zone and price, and get your licence moving the same day.

WHATSAPP	+971 52 346 9382
EMAIL	info@thestartupzone.ae
WEBSITE	thestartupzone.ae
VISIT US	Latifa Tower, Suite 801, Sheikh Zayed Road, Dubai, UAE

Scan to chat on WhatsApp

Book your free consultation →

ZONE startUP

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